



ALMA MATER STUDIORUM
UNIVERSITÀ DI BOLOGNA

Layers of cooperation: The interactional architecture of spoken language

Lecture 2

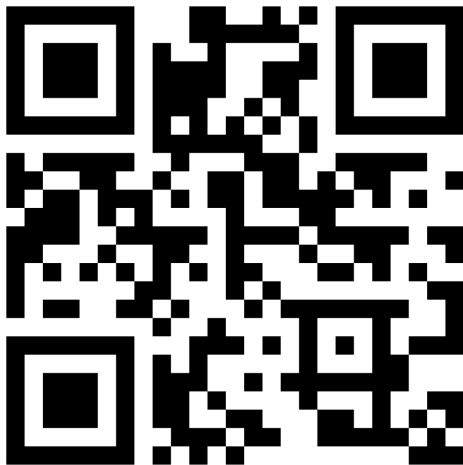
Collaborative meaning-making

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Three lectures: where we are now

Day	Lecture	Focus
19/5	Interaction as infrastructure	cooperative coordination, monitoring, reciprocity
20/5	Collaborative meaning-making	inferential cooperation, categorization, exemplification
22/5	Emergent syntax and co-construction	syntax across speakers, turns and trajectories

»»➔ The question is no longer only whether participants are aligned, but how they cooperatively build what they are talking about.

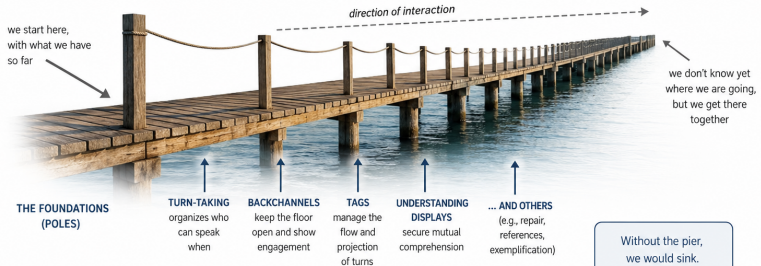
> The pier metaphor

INTERACTION AS INFRASTRUCTURE: THE PIER THAT MAKES LANGUAGE POSSIBLE

Spoken language is like a pier built while we walk on it.
We cannot step outside interaction to build it in advance:
the very act of interacting is what holds us, carries us,
and allows us to move forward together.

Language is not a pre-built
structure we use to interact.

**It is the structure we
build while interacting.**



These poles are not optional add-ons:
they are the infrastructure that keeps interaction stable
and allows language to emerge, moment by moment.

Without the pier,
we would sink.
Without the poles,
the pier would collapse.

Lecture 2: collaborative meaning-making

The discussion develops through five interconnected steps:

0. **Theoretical foundations**
meaning as interactionally achieved, grounded and inferentially reconstructed
1. **Inferential triggers**
exemplifiers, general extenders, non-exhaustive connectives and reference extenders
2. **Sequential patterns of cooperation**
recurrent trajectories of exemplification, feedback and category stabilization
3. **Social categorization**
constructing social types and identities through inferential interaction



Lecture 2: analytical notation

The examples are annotated with a stable color code so that the same analytical distinction is visible across case studies.

trigger **exemplar/frame** **abstract meaning** **stance/alignment**

Trigger	linguistic form that makes inferential work relevant
Exemplar/frame	concrete instance or scene to guide abstraction
Abstracted meaning	category, frame or property reconstructed from the local evidence
Stance/alignment	feedback, uptake or evaluation that stabilizes or redirects the category

»»» The notation separates linguistic resource, inferential operation and interactional evidence.

Starting example: a category in progress

- A *hai presente le città **tipo Torino*** you know cities like Turin
- B ***Bologna**, sì* Bologna, yes
- C ***secondo me** più **Firenze*** more like Florence, in my opinion
- A ***mhmh*** mhmh
- B ***città d'arte*** art cities
- A ***sì, esatto*** yes, exactly

»➔ The category is not simply retrieved. It is incrementally achieved through interaction.

0/ Shared background: cooperation

Human communication is characterized by a high degree of cooperativeness, which is not accidental but foundational.

- ▶ **Tomasello** (2023: 64–75)
shared intentionality is a defining feature of human cognition; the ability of humans to engage in joint attention and shared goals is what made the evolution of language (and grammar) possible
- ▶ **Clark** (1997: 584)
communication is “much like playing a duet: it requires the tight coordination of the participants at all times and at all levels.”
- ▶ **Sacks et al.** (1974), **Couper-Kuhlen & Selting** (2001), **Schegloff** (1992; 2007), **Deppermann** (2011), **De Stefani** (2013, 2020)
reference is a situated, interactional and multimodal practice, cooperatively achieved turn by turn

0/ Shared background: meaning

A use-based and interactional view treats meaning as an activity: meanings are stabilized in situated practices, not simply stored in forms.

- ✓ **Meaning as use**

Wittgenstein's formulation remains central: the meaning of a word is grounded in its use in language (Wittgenstein 1953).

- ✓ **Meaning as historically and socially unstable**

- ✓ **Meaning as interactional achievement**

meaning is an interactional achievement, situated in context and rooted in common ground. (Clark, 1996; Deppermann and De Stefani, 2023)

»»➔ The relevant question is therefore not only what a form means, but how participants **make it mean enough here and now.**

0/ Shared background: the addressee

Meaning is routinely partial and under-determined. This does not make communication defective; **it makes the addressee central.**

- ✓ **Underspecification**
forms rarely determine a single interpretation on their own; they provide resources that participants elaborate in context.
- ✓ **Multimodal and sequential evidence**
participants use wording, prosody, gaze, timing, response and repair to calibrate interpretation. cf. Goodwin 2007; (Deppermann and De Stefani, 2023)
- ✓ **Addressee agency**
the addressee is not only a recipient of encoded content, but a cognitive and social actor in the construction of shared meaning (Mauri, 2017, 2021; Mauri and Sansò, 2018; Voghera, 2017).

1/ Inferential cooperation

Some linguistic constructions do not fully specify the intended category or referential domain. Instead, they provide:

- ✓ partial semantic resources that make **inferential work relevant**
- ✓ **exemplars** (X_n) that guide the addressee toward a shared property (P)
- ✓ **open-ended projections** that invite the addressee to reconstruct a category or frame (C_P)
- ✓ **indexical interpretation** that relies on the local context and common ground

(Barsalou, 1983; Mauri, 2021; Mauri and Sansò, 2018)

$$X_1, X_2, \dots, X_n \rightarrow P$$

X_n	explicit exemplars or inferential resources provided in discourse
P	contextually reconstructed shared property
Inference	performed cooperatively by the addressee



1/ Types of inferential triggers

Inferential triggers are linguistic constructions that make inferential work relevant.

Linguistic strategy	Typical markers
Exemplifiers	<i>tipo, per esempio, magari</i>
General extenders	<i>eccetera, e cose così, or whatever</i>
Non-exhaustive connectives	<i>piuttosto che, Japanese toka</i>
Reference extenders	<i>tutto un N, una specie di</i>

»» These constructions partially underspecify meaning and recruit the addressee into **inferential completion** of some contextually relevant non-exhaustivity (*I mean more than what I am saying*).

(Barotto and Mauri, 2022; Mauri and Sansò, 2018)



1/ Exemplifiers

»»» The exemplars orient the addressee toward the intended abstraction.

TO083 [casa mia è] e::h=mh lievemente etnica.

TO083 ma lievemente. [...]

TO999 okay e::: come mai dici etnica?

TO083 etnica perché da qualche **viaggio dei miei**

tipo in Cambogia in Thailandia

abbiam portato

magari::=m:h=un tappeto appeso al muro:

oppure un quadro,

qualche piccolo elemento ma non è troppo.

TO999 **okay.**

[my house is] uh=mh slightly ethnic.

but slightly. [...]

okay and why do you say ethnic?

ethnic because from some **trips by my parents**

like to Cambodia to Thailand

we brought

maybe a carpet hanging on the wall:

or a painting,

some small element but not too much.

okay.

- ▶ **TRIGGER:** exemplification marker *tipo* 'like'
- ▶ **Exemplars:** X_{1p} (to Cambodia), X_{2p} (to Thailand)
- ▶ **Abstracted property:** exotic touristic destination
- ▶ **Category:** trips to exotic countries

1/ General extenders

»»➔ General extenders project a category beyond the explicitly mentioned item.

TO071 ti capisco benissimo perché io (.) arrivo
da un paese ehm

TO080 sì, molto più pic[colo]

TO071 [(anch)' io] **casetta isolata eccetera
eccetera**

sono venuto qui non ho dormito per mesi.

TO080 [e:h]

TO071 poi ti a=bitui

I understand you very well because I (.) come
from a town uhm

yes, much smaller

[(me too)] **little isolated house and so on
and so on**

I came here and didn't sleep for months.

[u:h]

then you get u=sed to it

-
- ▶ **TRIGGER:** general extender *eccetera eccetera* 'and so on and so on'
 - ▶ **Exemplar:** X_{1p} (*casetta isolata*)
 - ▶ **Abstracted property:** quiet, isolated environment far from urban noise
 - ▶ **Category:** calm life outside the city



1/ Non-exhaustive connectives

» Non-exhaustive connectives link examples within an open set (Barotto and Mauri, 2022)

BOI108 anche nel scoprire le:

BOI108 **le cose meno: e:h**

BOI108 **evidenti** che possono essere [non so]

BOI108 **piazza maggiore: [piuttosto che]**

BOR031 [sì]

BOI108 **via indipendenza piuttosto che** le cose

BOI108 e:h le: m:h **le sette chiese [piuttosto che]** le

classiche [cose] insomma]

BOR031 [sì]

also in discovering the:

the things uh less

obvious that can be [I don't know]

Piazza Maggiore: [or like]

[yes]

via Indipendenza or like the things

uh the **the Seven Churches [or like]** the

classic [things], in short]

[yes]

-
- ▶ **TRIGGER:** non-exhaustive connective *piuttosto che* 'or like'
 - ▶ **Exemplars:** X_{1p} (P.za Maggiore), X_{2p} (via Indipendenza), X_{3p} (Seven Churches)
 - ▶ **Abstracted property:** central and attractive for tourists
 - ▶ **Category:** usual touristic places to visit in Bologna

Reference extenders

» Strategies employed to trigger the activation of a **larger frame or category**, accessible through shared background knowledge and inferential enrichment (cf. Mauri & Masini 2024).

PKP057 quelli dello shabu gli danno **tot piatti**
che sono tipo

PKP057 **cinque o sei** tra cui scegliere cioè
non c'è **tutto un menu**

PKP062 **beh certo**

PKP057 **cinque o sei** e dopo il vino lì

those at Shabu give them a number of dishes
that are like

five or six to choose from, there is
there is not **a whole menu**

well, of course

five or six and then the wine

-
- ▶ **TRIGGER:** reference extender *tutto un* 'a whole'
 - ▶ **Activated frame:** large restaurant offering
 - ▶ **Inferred meaning:** abundance, complexity, many options

Reference extenders

» Strategies employed to trigger the activation of a **larger frame or category**, accessible through shared background knowledge and inferential enrichment (cf. Mauri & Masini 2024).

*perché i meridionali sopportano di essere
insultati da
una **Gelmini qualsiasi***
[CORIS]

*because southern Italians tolerate being
insulted by
some **random Gelmini?***
[CORIS]

-
- ▶ **TRIGGER:** [PN qualsiasi] used as category trigger
 - ▶ **Activated frame:** socially recognizable political persona
 - ▶ **Inferred meaning:** any representative of that perceived type

1/ What inferential triggers have in common

The strategies examined so far differ morphologically and interactionally.

But they share a common semantic architecture:

- ✓ partial semantic specification
- ✓ inferential completion
- ✓ indexical interpretation
- ✓ reliance on common ground
- ✓ cooperative reconstruction by the addressee

2/ From markers to sequences

So far, we have examined constructions that recruit the addressee into inferential cooperation: *tipo*, *eccetera*, *piuttosto che*, *tutto un*.

But cooperative meaning-making is not only encoded in isolated forms.

It emerges through recurrent **interactional trajectories**: how category formulations, examples, feedback and reformulations unfold across turns.

examples → category formulation → alignment

proposal → feedback → reformulation

(Zucchini and Mauri, 2026)



2/ Corpus sample

Bottom-up analysis based on a balanced sample of **14 conversations** from the KIParla corpus.

Interaction type	N	Duration
ParlaBO semi-structured interviews	3	2:42:38
Stra-ParlaBO semi-structured interviews	3	2:42:17
Interviews total	6	5:24:55
KIPasti free conversations	4	2:55:04
Stra-ParlaBO free conversations	4	2:44:19
Free conversations total	8	5:17:23
Total sample	14	11:04:18

Speakers involved	N	Duration	Tokens
L1	6	5:37:42	L1 102,017
L1 + L2	8	5:04:36	L2 24,440
Total	14	11:04:18	Total 126,457



2/ Unit of analysis

The unit of analysis is the **exemplification sequence**: a stretch of interaction in which speakers construct a category through exemplification, inferential reconstruction, feedback or reformulation.

»»➔ The analysis identifies **167 exemplification sequences**.

2/ Annotation architecture: sequence levels

The analysis treats exemplification as a sequential phenomenon unfolding across interaction.

Each exemplification sequence is annotated at two interconnected levels.

Sequence level	main or nested sequence; co-construction; initiating speaker; explicit category; explicit marker; feedback; interaction type
Within-sequence level	category formulation; exemplification; feedback; reformulation; inferential reconstruction; category stabilization

»➡ The goal is not only to identify markers, but to reconstruct how categories emerge interactionally.

2/ Annotation architecture: tracked dimensions

The annotation further tracks the recurrent organization of exemplification across speakers and turns.

- ✓ directionality (category → examples vs. examples → category)
- ✓ degree of explicitness (explicit vs. implicit category formulation and exemplification)
- ✓ interactional negotiation and alignment (feedback, negotiation, co-construction)

» A unitary analytical grid makes recurrent patterns visible across different interactional configurations.

2/ Global quantitative picture

Feature	n	%	basis
Identified exemplification sequences	167	100	all
Co-constructed sequences	40	24	167
Sequences without explicit exemplifier	81	49	167
Sequences without explicit category	63	38	167
Sequences beginning with category formulation	89	62	144
Sequences beginning with exemplification	55	38	144
Sequences containing feedback or negotiation	81	56	144
Sequences ending with feedback	65	45	144
Sequences containing nested exemplification	21	15	144

» Two points are especially important: implicit inferential reconstruction is frequent, and feedback is structurally central to category stabilization.

Percentages are calculated over all identified sequences (n=167) or over sequences comparable for sequential configuration (n=144), as indicated in the basis column.



2/ Four recurrent configurations

The bottom-up analysis identifies four recurrent configurations of cooperative meaning-making.

Configuration	Sequential movement	n	%
Linear explicit	category → exemplification	52	36
Inferential	exemplification → category formulation	55	38
Strong negotiation	proposal → feedback → reformulation	16	11
Recursive	nested exemplification sequences	21	15

The configurations differ in directionality, explicitness and participation, but all involve progressive category stabilization.

n=144; rounded percentages; (Zucchini and Mauri, 2026)

2/ Configuration 1: linear explicit

In the linear explicit configuration, the category is formulated first and subsequently specified through examples.

PSB033 *seguì qualche sport qua a Bologna?*

do you follow any sport here
in Bologna?

PSB035 *ehm: shuō shá?*

uhm: say what?

PSB014 *calcio*

football

PSB035 *io no però, non c'è tempo*

not me, there is no time

(KIParla, Stra-ParlaBO, PSB033)

Stage 1 category formulation: *sport*

Stage 2 exemplification: *calcio*

Stage 3 response and alignment

category formulation → exemplification → alignment



2/ Configuration 2: inferential

In the inferential configuration, examples precede explicit category formulation.

BOI067 *e forse è facile cadere in qualche*

BOI067 *trappola, vizio piuttosto che*

BOR020 *ah dici di perdersi?*

BOI067 *un po'*

(KIParla, PBA018)

and maybe it is easy to fall into some

trap, bad habit, or the like

ah, you mean losing oneself?

a little bit

Stage 1

exemplification: *trappola, vizio*

Stage 2

inferential category formulation by addressee

Stage 3

ratification

examples → inferential category formulation → ratification

2/ Configuration 3: strong negotiation

In strong negotiation, category stabilization emerges through stance, feedback and reformulation.

PKP014 *portarle qualcosa anche noi*

we too could bring her something

PKP014 *un pensierino o qualcosa non so*

a small gift or something, I don't know

PKP021 *sì sì*

yes yes

PKP020 *sì sarebbe carino*

yes, that would be nice

PKP014 *bere, mangiare*

something to drink, something to eat

PKP020 *dei fiori anche*

flowers too

PKP014 *no no ma fiori... che tristezza*

no no, flowers... how sad

PKP021 *no, i fiori*

no, the flowers

PKP014 *no, anche una cestina*

no, also a basket

PKP020 *vabbè era per dire*

well, it was just to say

► The category is negotiated through candidate examples, rejection and affective stance.

2/ Configuration 3: stages of negotiation

After the rejection of *fiori*, the category is reformulated and made interactionally acceptable.

PKP014 **qualcosa di particolare**

something special

PKP014 *comunque le fa piacere come pensiero*

in any case she will appreciate the thought

PKP021 **certo, sì sì**

of course, yes yes

PKP020 ***i fiori magari no***

flowers maybe not

Stage 1 category projection: *un pensierino o qualcosa*

Stage 2 candidate exemplars: *bere, mangiare, fiori*

Stage 3 negative feedback and stance: *che tristezza*

Stage 4 revision: *una cestina, qualcosa di particolare*

Stage 5 ratification: *certo, sì sì*



2/ Strong negotiation: testing the category

The example does not simply list possible gifts. Each turn changes the state of the emerging category.

Sequential step	Strategy	Interactional effect
Opening category	<i>un pensierino o qualcosa</i>	a small gift is projected, but still under-specified
First exemplars	<i>bere, mangiare</i>	the category is treated as practically fillable
Candidate extension	<i>dei fiori anche</i>	a co-participant proposes a socially recognizable option
Rejection	<i>no no, che tristezza</i>	the option is excluded through evaluation, not definition

2/ Strong negotiation: repairing the category

After rejection, the participants repair the proposal and progressively converge on a narrower category.

Sequential step	Strategy	Interactional effect
Repair of proposal	<i>era per dire</i>	the rejected example is downgraded as merely illustrative
Reformulation	<i>una cestina, qualcosa di particolare</i>	the target category becomes more specific
Alignment	<i>certo, sì sì, magari no</i>	participants converge on the revised boundary

» Strong negotiation is radical because examples are not only added: they are tested, evaluated, rejected and repaired in real time.

2/ Configuration 4: recursive

Recursive configurations contain one exemplification process embedded inside another.

BOI064 *tanta **umanità** vedo qua*

BOI064 *quando qualcuno vede **un invalido***

BOI064 ***una persona cieca***

BOI064 ***piuttosto che una persona in carrozzina***

BOI064 *c'è sempre una grandissima **umanità***

BOI064 ***ad esempio c'era questa signora***

I see a lot of **humanity** here

when someone sees a **person with a disability**

a blind person

or like a person in a wheelchair

there is always great **humanity**

for example, there was this woman

Stage 1 abstract category: *umanità*

Stage 2 first exemplification layer — *invalido*

Stage 3 nested exemplification sequence

2/ What the patterns show

The recurrent configurations show that feedback, negotiation, co-construction and recursion are not isolated effects.

They form **recurrent sequential patterns** built around continuous movements between:

- ✓ **abstraction** and **experience**
- ✓ **explicit** formulation and **inferential** construction
- ✓ speaker initiative and addressee contribution
- ✓ proposal, feedback and reformulation

Categories become stable only when they are sufficiently usable for the ongoing interaction.

3/ Social categorization in interaction

The inferential mechanisms discussed so far are not restricted to ordinary reference. They also emerge when speakers construct social types and identities in interaction. This becomes especially visible in categorizing relative constructions such as:

uno che ‘someone who’ *quelli che* ‘those who’

Rather than selecting a fixed label, these constructions allow speakers to:

- ✓ build categories incrementally
- ✓ define people through practices and properties
- ✓ negotiate socially relevant distinctions
- ✓ construct ad hoc social types

The category is not presupposed. It emerges through description and inference.



3/ Social categories in Stra-ParlaBO

The examples discussed in this section come from the *Stra-ParlaBO* module of KIParla (Mauri, Ballarè, et al., 2019).

The corpus includes:

- ✓ speakers with migration backgrounds
- ✓ spontaneous conversations and interviews
- ✓ mostly Italian interaction
- ✓ negotiation of identity, belonging and social experience

Social categorization becomes especially visible when speakers negotiate belonging, identity and social positioning.

3/ Analytical focus

The analysis focuses on categorizing relative constructions such as:

uno che *quelli che*

These constructions are especially suited to:

- ✓ constructing socially relevant categories incrementally
- ✓ describing people through practices and behaviours
- ✓ avoiding fixed taxonomic labels
- ✓ negotiating socially sensitive meanings interactionally

Out of **162 occurrences**, **58** involve ad hoc social categorization.

Social categories emerge through inferential and interactional work, not only through predefined labels.



3/ Four inferential strategies

The analysis identifies four recurrent inferential strategies.

Type	Inferential operation
Frame-based	activating shared experiential frames
Descriptive	categorizing through practices and behaviours
Referential	positioning an individual within a broader category
Exemplifying	constructing a category through accumulated examples

»»➔ The strategies are recurrent patterns for turning interactional evidence into social categories.

3/ Distribution of inferential strategies

The strategies recur with no single pattern accounting for the whole dataset.

Type	Count	Percent
Frame-based	12	20.7%
Descriptive	18	31.0%
Referential	14	24.1%
Exemplifying	14	24.1%

» Social categories emerge through recurrent inferential strategies, not only through predefined labels.

3/ Frame-based categorization

Frame-based categorization activates shared experiential knowledge rather than stable taxonomy.

SBCU005	eh ma uno che arriva qua senza famiglia senza lavoro senza niente	well, someone who arrives here without family, without work, without anything
SBCU005	cioe uno che deve ricominciare tutto	that is, someone who has to restart everything

Construction	<i>uno che</i>
Inferential basis	migration hardship frame
Category type	person restarting life from zero
Interactional effect	empathy and experiential alignment

The category is accessed through a shared social frame.

3/ Descriptive categorization

Descriptive categorization organizes social diversity through recurrent practices and behaviours.

PSB027	anche da noi c'è quelli che non fanno ramadan	among us too there are those who do not do Ramadan
PSB027	però non possono mangiare davanti te	but they cannot eat in front of you
PSB027	nascosti hai capito ci sono non è che non ci sono	hidden, you see , they exist, it is not that they do not
PSB005	ho capito	I understand

Construction

quelli che + behaviour

Inferential basis

religious practice

Category type

internally differentiated Muslim community

Interactional effect

pragmatic mapping of social diversity

Social distinctions emerge through practices rather than labels alone.



3/ Referential categorization (1)

Referential categorization embeds a referent within a broader class, expressing self-positioning or affiliation.

- ▶ the category is built in order to talk about the individual person
- ▶ building a larger category strengthens the relevance of the individual case and activates common ground

PSB104 *c(io)è nel senso è **una che soffre** e un po' che si fa (.) traversare dalla vita* I mean, **she's someone who suffers** and somehow lets life (.) flow through her

PSB104 *non so come spiegarlo (.) è come se: (.) si facesse passare un po' tutto addosso* I don't know how to explain it (.) it's as if (.) she let everything kind of wash over her

Referent	a specific individual
Categorizing relative	<i>una che soffre</i> 'someone who suffers'
Inferred category	person characterized by suffering and endurance
Interactional effect	the individual case is made interpretable through a broader social type



3/ Referential categorization (2)

PSB133	<i>io non sono uno che dice molte parolacce</i> <i>io non vado in chiesa a urlare le parolac[ce io per rispe]tto</i>	I'm not someone who swears a lot I don't go to church shouting swear [words, out of res]pect
--------	--	---

Referent	the speaker as individual
Categorizing relative	<i>uno che dice molte parolacce</i> 'someone who swears a lot'
Inferred category	person who habitually swears
Interactional effect	self-positioning through rejection of a socially recognizable type

»» Referential categorization can embed another person or the speaker herself within a broader social type.

3/ Exemplifying categorization

Exemplifying categorization constructs a social type through accumulated examples and properties.

PSB024	ma straniero non è un mostro	but a foreigner is not a monster
PSB024	lo straniero è uno che	a foreigner is someone who
PSB023	paga le tasse	pays taxes
PSB024	ti aiuta	helps you
PSB024	straniero è uno che lavora	a foreigner is someone who works
PSB024	che ti aiuta a pagare tua pensione	who helps you pay your pension

Starting label	<i>straniero</i>
Inferential strategy	accumulation of positive exemplars
Category type	productive and socially useful migrant
Interactional effect	ideological redefinition of the category

➡ A social prototype emerges through exemplification.



Take-home messages

1. Reference and categorization are interactional achievements, not static outputs of lexical meaning.
2. Some forms explicitly invite addressee cooperation: they work as indexical inferential triggers.
3. Exemplification connects concrete experience with abstract categories and makes them accessible in interaction.
4. Sequential evidence shows recurrent patterns of meaning-making across turns, speakers and interactional configurations.
5. Social categories show the broader stakes: interaction constructs what counts as shared, legitimate and recognizable.

»➡ Meaning is not simply exchanged: it is built, tested and projected as shared through recurrent cooperative patterns.

Towards Lecture 3

Today we have followed meaning as it is built across turns: examples, reformulations, categorization, feedback and projected sharedness.

The next step is syntax.

If meanings and categories can be co-constructed across speakers, we can ask whether grammatical organization may also unfold across interactional trajectories.

»»➔ From meaning woven across turns to grammar emerging across speakers.

Thanks!

Questions?

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